

Mexican art

A rich blend of many sources, Mexican art reflects a complex history. Centuries of colonial occupation and social protest evolved into civil war and revolution in the early 20th century. Following the revolution, the government commissioned artists to educate ordinary people about Mexican history. The Mexican Muralists, who included Diego Rivera (1886–1957), José Clemente Orozco (1883–1949) and David Alfaro Siqueiros (1896–1974), produced large, colourful murals on public buildings, mixing images from the country's troubled past, folk art and the art of the ancient Maya and Aztecs. The Muralists, who became known as *Los Tres Grandes* (The Three Great Ones), hoped their paintings would help to bring Mexican civilians together. Rivera painted colourful, idealistic images, Orozco produced darker, more pessimistic work and Siqueiros created satirical images using various materials. Rivera's wife, Frida Kahlo (1907–54), suffered lifelong health problems and expressed both her personal problems and her nationalistic feelings through autobiographical paintings, with specific Mexican references.



Rivera, *The Flowered Canoe*, 1931